

# Nationals to promote pitching prospect Jackson Kent for stretch run: Sources



Nationals prospect Jackson Kent has mid-rotation upside. Shawn Dowd / USA Today Network via Imagn Images



By **Spencer Nusbaum**

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With the Washington Nationals' youth movement at full tilt and the possibility of a playoff push front of mind, the organization is promoting one of its top healthy pitching prospects to Washington.

Left-hander Jackson Kent will join the roster before the team's upcoming series against the Chicago Cubs. He will make his MLB debut this week, team sources who spoke Monday on condition of anonymity because the move had not been

finalized told *The Athletic*. Kent will fill the vacated rotation spot of right-hander Zack Littell, who was designated for assignment last week.

Aided by a jump in velocity and a crafty pitch mix, the 23-year-old has pitched to a 3.72 ERA across 94 1/3 innings in Double and Triple A. He could offer meaningful upside to a starting rotation that ranks 25th in MLB in ERA. The Nationals are 59-61 and, after sweeping the Cincinnati Reds this weekend, enter Monday 4 1/2 games back of the final wild-card spot in the National League.

Jarlin Susana, also one of the organization's top pitching prospects, is slated to pitch in a minor-league game this week for the first time in nearly a year, said a person in the organization who spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss internal planning.

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Coaches have wanted to ease Susana back from right lat surgery, but the 22-year-old has struggled to keep his heater under 100 mph while rehabbing. He is expected to pitch in a short appearance for High-A Wilmington on Tuesday.

Kent’s impact is far more immediate. Washington selected Kent in the fourth round of the 2024 draft, admiring his pitch-ability, command and extension. Throughout the 2025 season, coaches and executives in the organization spoke glowingly of those traits and his makeup, but thought he could continue to evolve. After an offseason of training at the University of Arizona and working with the Nationals’ revamped player development group in-season, he has added velocity to augment his four-pitch mix this year.

Though the farm system hasn’t developed many October-ready arms over the last decade, Kent offers mid-rotation upside. All four of his pitches have missed bats in Rochester. He has struck out about 10 batters per nine innings while walking just 2.9 per nine. He is regarded as one of the system’s most cerebral thinkers. And while his stuff does not pop on a radar gun or a computer screen, he has been able to get both right-handed and left-handed hitters out — something organizations consider when evaluating their starting pitching prospects.

**Spencer Nusbaum** is a Staff Writer for The Athletic covering the Washington Nationals. Before joining The Athletic, he spent two years covering the Nationals for The Washington Post. He is a graduate of American University.

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